

Session 16: Law as Mission

Key Takeaways

- The Israelites were set free from oppression before they received the law. The law was not a means of earning God's compassion or protection.
- The law was not a burden. The law was seen as a mark of God's favor and a special distinction for the people of Israel.
- The law was likely given in duplicate on two tablets, as was common with covenant records, to act as a witness and reminder for both parties.

Literary Context of the Decalogue

The first question to ask in framing the literary context of the Ten Commandments is what has happened in the story so far leading up to Sinai? One prominent thing to note is that the law is given after they are already saved from slavery in Egypt. The law is not Israel's means of salvation!

Historical Context: How Did the Israelites View the Law?

Deuteronomy 4:5-8 NIV

⁵ See, I have taught you decrees and laws as the LORD my God commanded me, so that you may follow them in the land you are entering to take possession of it. ⁶ Observe them carefully, for this will show your wisdom and understanding to the nations, who will hear about all these decrees and say, "Surely this great nation is a wise and understanding people." ⁷ What other nation is so great as to have their gods near them the way the LORD our God is near us whenever we pray to him? ⁸ And what other nation is so great as to have such righteous decrees and laws as this body of laws I am setting before you today?

See also [Exodus 19:8](#); [24:3, 7](#)

The law was viewed as a gift of wisdom that set Israel apart from the other nations.

How Many Stone Tablets Were There?

Exodus 31:18 Instructor's Translation

When he finished speaking with him on Mount Sinai, he gave to Moses the **two tablets** of the [covenant] document (עֲדוּת), tablets of stone, inscribed by the finger of God.

Exodus 32:15 Instructor's Translation

And Moses turned and he went down from the mountain, and the **two tablets** of the [covenant] document (עדות) [were] in his hand, tablets inscribed on both sides, inscribed on front and back.

Exodus 40:20 Instructor's Translation

And he took and he set the [covenant] document (עדות) into the ark ...

What Is the Significance of Having Two Tablets?

Historical context provides insight into the practice of providing duplicate copies in a covenant ritual. In this excerpt from the treaty between Suppiluliuma and Shattiwaza, each party retains a copy to place in their temple so the gods can be witnesses and guarantors of the agreement.

“A duplicate of this tablet has been deposited before the sun-goddess of Arinna, because the sun-goddess of Arinna regulates kingship and queenship. In Mitanni land [a duplicate] has been deposited before Teshub, the lord of the [sanctuary] of Kahat. At regular [intervals] shall they read it in the presence of the king of the Mitanni land and in the presence of the sons of the Hurri country.”

Kitchen, Kenneth A. and Lawrence, Paul J. N. (2012). *Treaty, Law and Covenant in the Ancient Near East*. Harrassowitz. No. 56A, 1.391.

Reflection Question

What new insights have you gained about how the law functions in this narrative or in the biblical story?